Cheatsheet: Creating a Quarto Book

From installation to a published book

OUTPUT	STRUCTURE	BEST FOR
Multi-chapter document (HTML / PDF)	One project, `chapters:` list decides order	Lecture notes, handbooks, theses

1 — Setup

Install (once per computer):

- **VS Code** — code.visualstudio.com (tick **"Add to PATH"** during setup)
- **Quarto CLI** — quarto.org/docs/get-started
- **Quarto extension** for VS Code — search "Quarto" in the Extensions sidebar

Create the project: File → New File... → Quarto Project → Book Project → choose your folder. Quarto creates:

- `_quarto.yml` — book title, author, and chapter order
- `index.qmd` — cover / preface page
- `intro.qmd`, `summary.qmd` — example chapters (rename or replace)
- `references.bib` / `references.qmd` — bibliography file and its rendered page

Which one do I need?

Writing something long that's read front-to-back, in order — lecture notes, a handbook, a thesis — with an automatic table of contents and Previous/Next navigation? This is it. For loosely-linked standalone pages, see the **Website** cheatsheet; for one short, printable handout, see the **Exercise Sheet** cheatsheet.

2 — Organizing & writing chapters

Every chapter is a `.qmd` file. The order they appear in `_quarto.yml` is the order they appear in the book:

```yaml
book:
  title: "My Lecture Notes"
  author: "Your Name"
  chapters:
    - index.qmd
    - intro.qmd
    - summary.qmd
    - references.qmd
```

Add a chapter: create the new `.qmd` file, then add its filename to the `chapters:` list.

Each chapter file itself is written exactly like any other Quarto page — `##` headings, code cells, callouts, citations — see the Website cheatsheet for Markdown basics.

> Tip
>
> The reader gets a **left sidebar** with all chapters, **Previous / Next** links at the bottom of each page, and a **table of contents** for the current chapter — all generated automatically from the `chapters:` list.

Preview vs. Render:

Command	What it does	Use it when
`quarto preview`	Opens a live view with sidebar & navigation; updates on save	While you're writing and editing
`quarto render`	Builds the final book into `_book` (or `docs/`, if configured)	Before publishing

3 — Publish with GitHub Pages

A rendered book's `_book` folder works exactly like a website's `_site` folder — the steps are identical:

1. In `_quarto.yml`, under `project:`, add `output-dir: docs`
2. Render: `quarto render`
3. Create a **public** repository on github.com
4. Upload the whole project folder (including `docs/`) and commit
5. Repo → **Settings** → **Pages** → Branch `main`, folder `/docs` → **Save**
6. Wait for the green checkmark under **Deployments** — your book is live at `https://<username>.github.io/<repo-name>/`

Updating your book later: run `quarto render` again, then re-upload the `docs/` folder to GitHub (or `git push` if you're using Git).

Good to know

- Group chapters into named sections with `part:` in the `chapters:` list, e.g. `part: "Basics"` followed by its own nested `chapters:` list.
- Add an `appendices:` list at the book level — auto-numbered "Appendix A", "Appendix B", …
- Cross-reference any chapter from anywhere in the book: give a heading an id with `{#sec-intro}`, then link to it with `@sec-intro`.

Full details & screenshots: What you need · Create a Book · Publish a Website (same steps)